uncomfortable with the concept of the Indo-Pacific, which Russian Foreign Minister Sergei Lavrov once described as an artificially imposed construct promoted by the United States, Japan, and Australia to contain China and "to get India involved in military-political and naval processes."[21] For India, the Asia Pacific was a Cold War construct, excluding India (it extended from Southeast Asia to the United States' Pacific seaboard). The Indo-Pacific corrects that anomaly and defines a geographical area of economic and security interest to India. As Prime Minister Modi said at the Shangri La dialogue in Singapore in June 2018, India will work for a rules-based order in a free, open, and inclusive Indo-Pacific region.[22] Both in this speech and in other official statements, India has sought to distinguish between its concept of a free and open Indo-Pacific and the American Free and Open Indo-Pacific (FOIP) strategy, which is framed in ideological and military terms.

In his press statement in Vladivostok, Prime Minister Modi said he had a "useful discussion" with President Putin on "India's concept of an open and inclusive Indo-Pacific." President Putin talked in his statement of India and Russia working together for security and stability in the Pacific and Indian Oceans.[23] This is the closest a Russian leader has come to mentioning the Indo-Pacific in a positive light (even if he did not use the term). These statements, taken together with India's promise of substantial investments in the Russian Far East and Arctic regions, and the establishment of the Vladivostok-Chennai maritime trade corridor, may herald a substantive India–Russia dialogue on security and cooperation in the Indo-Pacific.

Russia has recently taken other steps that demonstrate that it is not tied down to the Chinese agenda in the region. It has reactivated its institutional dialogue with ASEAN. Contrary to popular belief, Russia has remained neutral on China's territorial disputes in the South China Sea. It has